



delaying enemy advances with mines, and Howitzers. They are also a lot more mobile with good infantry support providing tanks, like the Sherman FireFly and the Cromwell—the former a tank destroyer, and the latter a general purpose tank. The light Stuart battle tank makes short work of foot soldiers, and can be used to support advances against troop emplaced within structures and machine gun nests. The lumbering, heavily armoured Churchill tank is also available, in three avatars. The British infantry are also able builders, especially their sappers, who can also lay mines and wield anti tank weapons.

The Germans are also mobile, in fact, even more so, as they have the most powerful tanks in the game. While the British must build their tanks, the Germans have most of their tanks made available to them via the *command point* tree. Although they can only build a Panzer IV tank, you can summon powerful all purpose Panther tanks, tank hunter Hetzer tanks, and the super tank-hunter the *Jadgpanther*. In the campaign you will also get to control the King Tiger, a very powerful tank strong against most enemies. The Germans tend to bulldoze the map—once they get access to these powerful tanks.

Despite their differences I found both sides to be evenly matched, the British with their devastating artillery and the Axis, with their ability to booby trap

resource points and buildings. Relic's winning formula remains largely unchanged, except for faction changes, and why the heck not?

Environments and effects detail remain a treat for the eyes. Battlefields can be rain drenched, foggy, or arid, and everything from the totally destructible environments and structures is detailed to perfection. Remnants of vehicles, scorched bodies, and debris can be seen after battles, even terrain deformation is impressive. All weapon effects are impressive, and attention to detail is good—for example, you will witness details like the smoke that comes out of a tank's exhaust, or the recoil of a shoulder mounted bazooka. Troops will seek cover if fired upon, and their desperate scampering around amid shouted orders really sets the tone for realism.

The multiplayer component is robust, but due to the high system requirements, you may be hard pressed to find servers. Skirmish mode against AI opponents is fun though.

For me *COH: Opposing Fronts* is a game virtually sans flaws. I happen to have a fast PC with a quad core, 4 GB of RAM and a GeForce 8800GTX graphics card, so I could enjoy this game in all its splendour. And I've never come across a better WW2 based RTS experience!

michael.browne@thinkdigit.com

The fearsome King Tiger in action



German infantry go to work repairing a damaged tank



Infantry with a Nebelwerfer rocket artillery in the foreground

